



■ By Shankkar Aiyar

It is what apocryphal stories are made of, only this is true. Some time in the early 1980s, Mukesh Ambani was on a flight from Mumbai to Delhi. The flight, thanks to the fog over Delhi, was diverted to Ahmedabad. Stranded, Mukesh had to borrow money from a fellow passenger. He was carrying neither money nor a credit card. Even today, Mukesh, estimated to be the richest man in the world, never carries cash or credit cards, at home or abroad. When you create wealth, you don't carry it, it carries you.

And we are not talking small wealth here. Sure he is a few Sensex points away from pole position in terms of market capitalisation. But the sum total of the value of all his investments—including the holding in Reliance Industries—is in excess of \$60 billion (Rs 2,40,000 crore). If Mukesh was a nation and his wealth was his GDP, he would rank somewhere in the 50s in the list of 181 countries, give or take a few billions. If that sounds too distant and numerical, try this: if you can count one dollar a second, it would take about 15 days to count a million and about 30 years to count one billion dollars. In rupee terms \$60 billion is more than twice the total income tax that will be collected this year. Mukesh, though, loathes the buzz, the idea of being called the richest man in the world. In almost a monologue, he says, "If the purpose of business is only to make money, then it is a poor business model. If you can't impact millions of lives then it is a pointless exercise."

Personally he is happiest sharing black gram from Mahabaleshwar with colleagues at late night meetings at Maker IV, or stopping by at Madras Café in Matunga for his dosa binge or snack on Gujarati farsan from the shops at Dadar Kabutharkhana. Bliss is a walk around the US Club in Mumbai, eating bajra roti and

MUKESH AMBANI

BHASKAR PAUL

Machine

BETTING ON INDIA, THINKING BIG AND EXECUTING MEGA PROJECTS AT A BLISTERING PACE
MAKE THE RELIANCE CHAIRMAN AMONG THE RICHEST WEALTH CREATORS IN THE WORLD